

Big Man For Complex Job!

Planting Herrera At Second Would Be Major Transition

The largest second base candidate in the major leagues is with the Phillies.

That's Frank (Pancho) Herrera. By inclination and habit he's a first baseman. He has sure, soft hands and surprising agility. Herrera weighs 230 pounds, and is 6-2 in height.

For that reason:

1. He hit .329 last season and hit 37 homers at Buffalo.
2. Ed Bouchee is entrenched at first base.

So, the Phillies need the big Cuban's bat, and they're trying him at a new position.

It would be a revolutionary transition, for second basemen are usually lithe, swift fellows, and their trade is the most complex on the field. The other candidates include George Anderson, Bob Malkmus, and Ted Lepico — all of them fit into that physical category.

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ACTUALLY, Herrera has no played second base since arriving with the Phillies after a successful campaign in the Cuban Winter League.

"For a fellow who never played the position before," says Manager Eddie Sawyer, "he's doing

an acceptable job. Last year he was going to play third base at Buffalo, but he broke his leg playing in Cuba and so he was anchored at first base. Right now our job is to get him acquainted with a five-fingered glove."

Herrera says, "I'll play anywhere. I like first base natural-

ly, but I want to make the team playing somewhere."

Pancho has surprised everyone with his nibleness at second base, handling everything that is hit his way, even pivoting successfully on a double play.

"There are a lot of things you have to do at second base," observes Coach Andy Cohen, "but making the double play is most important. For a big fellow like Herrera he sure has all the moves."

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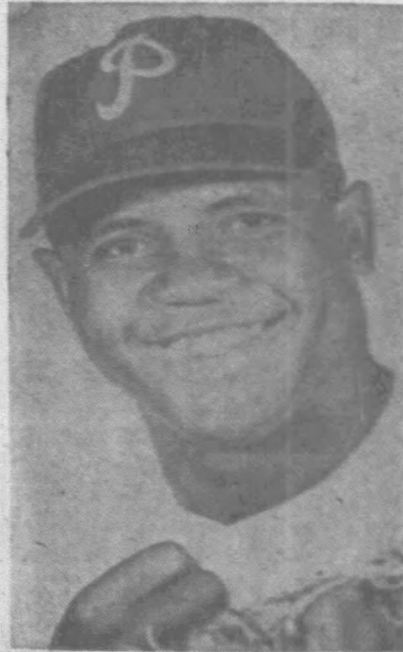
IF HERRERA doesn't make it right away at second base, he may become an all-purpose utility man.

"He might play any of the infield positions except shortstop," Sawyer says. "And if he shows anything at bat, he'll be hard to budge. We can always use runs."

Herrera, 28, claims he's a better hitter than ever, crediting a new, level swing and the patience to wait for good pitches as the solution to his weakness.

"Don't worry about Pancho," Pancho says. "If he gets a good chance, he will hit."

The notion entrances Sawyer. "Can you imagine," he says wistfully, "a second baseman batting cleanup?"



FRANK HERRERA